alleged, ‘Indian troops, attempting to stage a come-back, have continued repeatedly to cross the boundary for reconnaissance, and even launched armed attacks against the Chinese frontier guards. It is perfectly clear that India has been using Sikkim’s territory to commit ceaseless intrusions and provocations against China and create tension on the China-Sikkim boundary.’ The note went on to remind people of the ‘fact’ that it is ‘well known’ that India had launched ‘a massive attack on China’ in October 1962’.[30]

India’s Prime Minister Shastri could perhaps have extracted more concessions from Pakistan when he signed the deal brokered by the Soviet Union in Tashkent on 10 January 1966. That is debatable, but the appointment of Indira Gandhi as India’s new prime minister definitely marked the beginning of a new and more assertive India. She was not going to tolerate any more provocations from China.

China did not attack, but, in July 1966, its troops opposite Nathu La installed six powerful loudspeakers blaring out propaganda at the Indian troops stationed at the pass. In August, loudspeakers were also put opposite Jelep La. Huge portraits of Mao Zedong were erected at both border passes, facing the Indians. But it is doubtful those manoeuvres had any impact on the morale of the Indian soldiers. The nuisance value was greater, as the noise from the loudspeakers may have deprived the soldiers of some sleep.

Small-scale incursions by the Chinese continued as well. Then, open confrontation broke out when, on 11 September 1966, the Indian troops announced over loudspeakers that they had no intention of intruding even one millimetre into Tibet. After the announcement was made, the Indian troops began putting up barbed wire along the border on the southern side of Nathu La. The Chinese then opened fire with automatic rifles and light-machine guns, killing and wounding several Indian soldiers. The Indian side returned fire and the Chinese upped the ante by firing 76mm and 122mm cannons. The Indians responded with their artillery, killing and wounding at least 36 PLA soldiers.

The Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs stated in a note given to the Indian Embassy in Beijing on 12 September, ‘Do not misjudge the situation and repeat your mistake of 1962…the Chinese People’s Liberation Army will certainly deal a crushing blow at any enemy who dares to invade us’.[31] But the Indian soldiers had not crossed into Tibet, nor had they vacated any